

Case Study: Men's Circle India — Filling Free Listening Circles on a Shoestring Meta Ads Budget

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At a glance

By switching from lead-form ads to a message-first funnel, I cut Men's Circle India's cost per sign-up from ₹184 to ₹34 and grew the sign-up list from 215 to 909 men, on a total Meta Ads spend of ₹38,514 across 10 months.

Metric	Before	After
Cost per lead	₹184	₹34 (−82%)
Sign-up list	215 men	909 men (4.2x)
Instagram/Facebook followers	256	1,100 (4.3x)
Daily sign-ups	1–2	Bangalore now fills without paid ads
Total ad spend	₹0	₹38,514 (Jan–Oct 2026)

- **Client:** Men's Circle India, a men's support community running free Listening Circles
- **Role:** Paid social strategy, campaign setup, chat automation and creative direction
- **Channels:** Meta Ads (Facebook and Instagram)
- **Cities:** Bangalore, Delhi, Hyderabad, Pune, Mumbai, Gurugram, Chennai

The client and the challenge

Men's Circle India runs Listening Circles: free, in-person support sessions where men can speak openly and be heard. I came on board in January 2026 with one job: get men to sign up and show up.

Three constraints shaped everything:

- **A tight budget.** Roughly ₹3,000 per campaign, run at about ₹500 a day.
- **A free offer.** With no price to discount, the ads had to sell the value of showing up, not a deal.

- **A sensitive ask.** Many men hesitate to seek emotional support. A cold "fill this form" ad asks for commitment before trust exists.

The client's brief was simple: maximum sign-ups for every rupee spent.

Phase 1: Lead generation straight to a form

The first campaign launched on 10 January 2026 for a Bangalore Listening Circle. It ran on Meta's Lead Generation objective at ₹500 a day.

Setup

- Broad location targeting at the ad set level, letting Meta's algorithm find the audience within the city
- Two creatives: one video and one static image
- Both linked directly to a Google Form for sign-up

What happened

Cost per lead came in at ₹184, with only 1–2 sign-ups a day. I ran the same structure for Delhi and then Hyderabad to test whether the city was the problem. The results held steady, which pointed to the funnel itself.

Diagnosis

The ad asked a hesitant audience to leave Instagram, open a form and commit, all in one step. For a free, emotionally sensitive offer, that leap was too big. Men who were curious had no low-pressure way to ask a question first.

Phase 2: From "fill this form" to "send us a message"

After the three city campaigns, I changed the objective from Lead Generation to Engagement. Instead of sending men to a form, the ads now invited them to message Men's Circle India directly.

The new journey

1. A man sees the ad and taps to send a message, a small, private first step.
2. Meta's built-in automation replies instantly, so no enquiry waits for a human.
3. The automated reply shares the Google Form link to sign up.
4. He signs up, already in conversation with the community.

Why it worked

- **Lower barrier.** Sending a message feels like asking a question, not making a commitment.

- **Instant response.** Automation meant every enquiry got the sign-up link within seconds, at any hour.
- **Warmer leads.** Men who messaged first had already chosen to engage, so more of them completed the form.
- **No extra cost.** The automation used Meta's native tools, with no paid chatbot software.

Creative: Statics, redesigned for how the eye reads

Testing showed that static images outperformed video for Men's Circle India. So I put the creative effort into making the statics sharper rather than producing more video.

- **Left-to-right flow.** Each layout follows the natural reading path of the eye, so the message lands in order: the hook, the context, then the call to message.
- **Less text.** I cut copy on the image to the essentials, letting one clear idea carry each ad.
- **Fast to iterate.** Statics are cheaper and quicker to produce than video, so a small budget could still test new versions often.

Results

Cost per lead fell from ₹184 to ₹34, an 82% drop, on a total spend of ₹38,514 from January to October 2026.

- **Sign-ups:** The list grew from 215 to 909 men, more than four times its starting size.
- **Bangalore is now self-sustaining.** Word of mouth and the existing community now fill Bangalore circles without paid ads, freeing budget for other cities.
- **A bonus audience.** Followers grew from 256 to 1,100 in 7 months as a side effect of the Engagement objective, at no added cost. Every new follower is a man who can be reached organically for future circles.

For context, at the original ₹184 per lead, ₹38,514 would have bought about 209 sign-ups. The new funnel delivered far more for the same money.

Special campaign: Support for men facing job loss

When mass layoffs hit Bangalore, Men's Circle India hosted a meetup for men who had been laid off. I built a separate campaign around it, leaning on three levers.

- **Hiring partners as the hook.** Companies had come on board to mentor and hire attendees. The ads led with this, turning a support meetup into a concrete path back to work.

- **Venue credibility.** The event was held at the Nasdaq office in Bangalore. I featured the venue prominently, signalling a serious, professional setting.
- **Scarcity and FOMO.** With only 50 spots, the ads made the limit clear to drive quick sign-ups.

Targeting again used broad location settings across Bangalore, letting Meta find men responding to the layoff message.

Results

Men filled out the sign-up form, shared their CVs with us ahead of the meetup, and attended on the day. Two of them landed jobs at the event itself. The campaign's spend came out of the same ₹38,514 total budget, so it delivered these outcomes without any extra money.

Key learnings

1. **Match the ask to the audience's readiness.** For a sensitive, free offer, a message converts better than a form because it asks for less trust up front.
2. **The objective is a strategic choice, not a default.** "Lead Generation" sounded right for sign-ups, but Engagement plus automation delivered leads at a fifth of the cost.
3. **Automation makes small budgets work harder.** Instant replies captured every enquiry without adding staff or tools.
4. **Test formats, then double down.** Once statics proved stronger, refining them beat spreading budget across formats.
5. **Good paid work compounds into organic growth.** Bangalore now runs without ads, and 1,100 followers form an audience the client owns.